Kanban Delivery Acceptance and Flow Policy

1. Objective

This policy defines the evidence required before work may move through the Kanban system. It separates workflow state from delivery assurance: a card can move between lanes, but release readiness still depends on acceptance intent, validation evidence, unresolved defects, and scope.

2. Entry Criteria

- A card entering Ready must have a clear business outcome.
- Known dependencies must be identified.
- Release-critical cards require a named owner and current acceptance evidence.

3. Flow Rules

From	To	Required Evidence
Backlog	Ready	Outcome, owner, dependencies
Ready	Doing	Capacity available; blocking dependency addressed
Doing	Review	Acceptance evidence attached; regression impact identified
Review	Done	Validation complete; critical defects resolved; links updated

4. Blocked Work

Blocked work remains part of delivery risk. A blocked release-critical item should not disappear from readiness reporting simply because the team has moved other cards to Done. The blockage reason, age, and affected feature should remain visible.

5. Acceptance Quality

Statements such as “works well,” “looks good,” or “responds quickly” are not sufficient unless accompanied by observable or measurable criteria. Teams should clarify the expected behavior before treating such cards as validation-ready.

6. Defect Interaction

A card can be functionally complete while still carrying release risk through an unresolved defect. Severity, reproducibility, affected feature, and workaround availability all influence the delivery decision.

7. Evidence Expectations

- Current test execution result for release-critical behavior.
- Link from card to the relevant acceptance evidence.
- Defect references where failures remain open.
- Explanation when a blocked test is accepted as a release exception.

8. State Is Not Evidence

Done indicates a workflow state, not a guarantee that the associated business outcome is safe to release. The delivery-assurance application should combine board data with tests, defects, and release scope before reaching a conclusion.

9. Flow Metrics

Cycle time and work-in-progress are useful operational metrics, but they should not replace requirement and validation evidence. A fast-moving card with weak acceptance criteria may still represent delivery risk.

10. Source Precedence

Current board state and current acceptance policy should be used together. Historical comments may explain why a card changed, but they should not override approved release gates without explicit evidence.